

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 218

Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1974-1976

Coverage Date: 1950-1976

Place Coverage: Southwestern Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): SPEECH DIRECTED TO THE INFANT

The same general contour holds for all positive utterances, which includes not only Soothing but also Praise (appearing in less than 1% of all minutes of observation) and Endearment (5.8%), that is, calling the baby *baba* ("mother"), *tata* ("father"), or *monene* ("big boy"). Figure 8.9c shows a major drop in positive utterances after the first few months, followed by a lower level during the second year.

[191](#)
[Speech](#)

[854](#)
[Infant Care](#)

Negative utterances directed to the infant rise after 1 year of age and remain a larger proportion of all utterances through the second year. This category consists of Negative Commands like *Tiga!* ("Stop"), and *Karwo!* ("Get away!"), which are most frequent; warnings such as "You'll fall," or "You'll get burned"; and threats such as "I'll beat you!" One kind of warning intended to

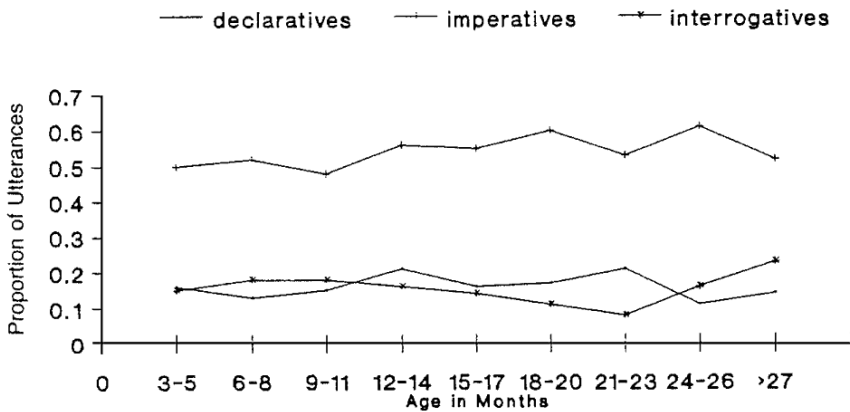
[113](#)
[Bibliographies In Sources](#)

[191](#)
[Speech](#)

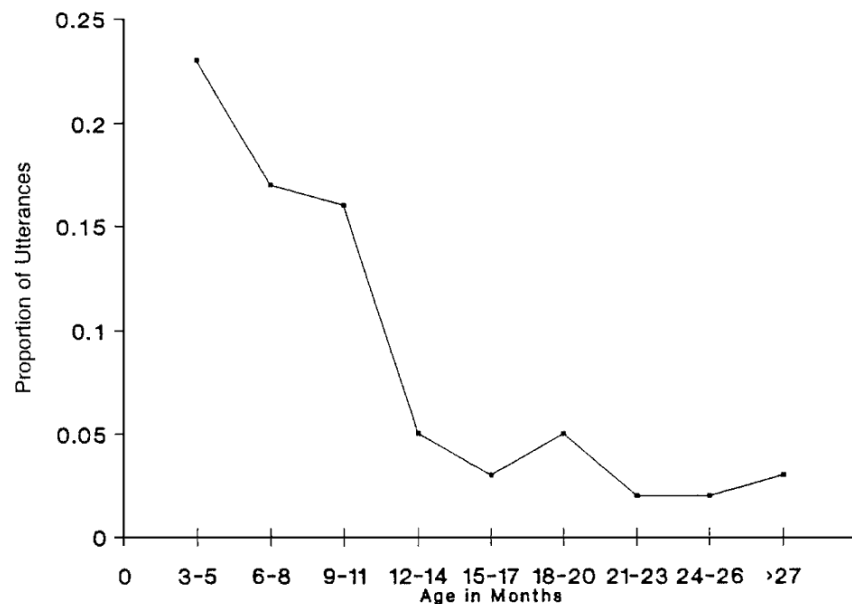
[854](#)
[Infant Care](#)

[861](#)
[Techniques Of Socialization](#)

8.9a Infant-directed declarative, imperative, and interrogative utterances from all caregivers, by infant age ($n = 28$).

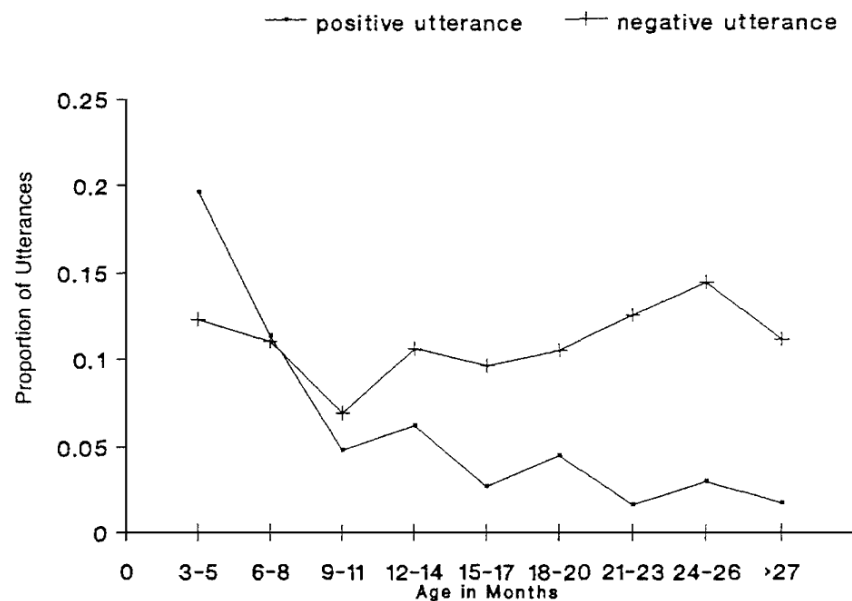


8.9b Proportion of infant-directed utterances that were soothing, from all caregivers by infant age ($n = 28$).



frighten the baby involves pretending to call a dog (*Aso, aso, esese!*) or an imaginary animal (*ekuku*, a rare baby-talk word meant to refer to an animal that might hurt one).¹³ For example, when her 9-month-old daughter approached an axe, a mother ■ 220

8.9c Overall proportions of negative and positive utterances directed to infants from all caretakers by infant age ($n = 28$).



shouted, "Kuku!" to stop her. Sometimes mothers seem to be joking in their threats, and as children get older, they appear not to take them seriously: In one observation, for example, a 30-month-old girl asks her mother for a banana. When the mother says, "Go and get one," the girl accuses her mother of having eaten her banana; the mother defends her authority by saying, "Today your uncle will beat you hard," whereupon the little girl says, "I'll run away." Though overt verbal defiance of this kind is rare, the understanding that maternal threats are not genuine may be widespread among Gusii children during their third year of life.

13. See Levine and Levine (1966, pp. 125–126) for a description of this phenomenon in the 1950s.

*755 Prospect Street
New Haven, CT 06511*

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)